

The Behavior Translator

Ten things you have probably seen — and what your child’s nervous system may be trying to say underneath them.

Behavior is communication. When a child can’t say what is happening inside, the body says it instead. This sheet is a starting place, not a diagnosis and not a rule book. Read the middle column as a *maybe*, never a verdict — you know your child better than any chart does. It just gives you somewhere to look first, and something to try while you look.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MIGHT BE ASKING FOR	WHAT TO TRY RIGHT NOW
• A meltdown right after a good day at school	Capacity ran out. Holding it together all day costs something, and home is where it’s finally safe to stop holding.	Skip the questions for the first twenty minutes. Lower the light and the noise. Water, a snack, a blanket. Debrief tomorrow, not tonight.
• “I don’t know” to every question	The words aren’t there yet — or the question needs more processing time than the moment allows.	Swap open questions for two choices. Or ask again later, in writing, side by side instead of face to face.
• The same song, video or phrase on repeat	Predictability is regulating. Repetition is the brain finding solid ground.	Let it run. Then use it on purpose — the same song, deliberately, before a hard transition.
• Stuck at the door, can’t leave the house	The transition is bigger than the capacity available for it right now. It isn’t refusal.	Shrink the step. “Shoes now. Door in five.” Warn earlier than feels necessary — every single time.
• A huge reaction to a small thing	It was the last thing, not the only thing. The stack was already full before you got there.	Name the stack, not the trigger. “That’s a lot at once.” Don’t argue about the size of the reaction.
• Going quiet, flat, or disappearing into a room	Shutdown — overload turned inward. It can look like calm. It isn’t.	Stay near. Stop asking. Take input away rather than adding more. Silence is not refusal.
• Hitting, throwing, running	The body found the fastest exit from something unbearable. In that moment there is no access to reasoning.	Safety first, words much later. Never teach during. Repair afterward, without a lecture.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MIGHT BE ASKING FOR	WHAT TO TRY RIGHT NOW
● "I'm fine" when they are clearly not	There may be no language for the feeling yet — or past experience says naming it makes things worse.	Offer a number instead of a word: "Where are you, one to ten?" Or name what you see without needing them to agree.
● Can't sit still, constant movement	The body is seeking input so the brain can stay online and pay attention.	Allow movement during listening. Movement isn't the opposite of attention — often it's the price of it.
● Falling apart over a change of plan	Knowing what came next was the safety. Losing it is losing the floor.	Give the new plan in writing or pictures, and name one thing that has <i>not</i> changed.

Three sentences that work in almost any moment

"I'm right here."

Presence without demand. It asks for nothing back.

"You don't have to explain it right now."

Removes the pressure to produce language during overload.

"This is hard. That's okay."

Validates without fixing. Fixing comes much later.

Say one of them — then stop talking. The pause is the tool.

ONE MORE THING

The goal was never a child who stops melting down. It is a child who slowly learns to read their own signals — and the adults around them all working from the same page. Most of what exhausts families isn't the child. It's having to explain the child again, from scratch, to every new person.

This sheet is general. Your child isn't.

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